

The FEAR FACTOR

A spate of hate crimes against Indian students causes concern and outrage, forcing the Australian Government to take strong measures

| By David McMahon in Melbourne |

Australia has always regarded itself as The Lucky Country. That and the promise of quality education at a reasonable cost with the good life thrown in saw Indian students come in droves in the past few years. By last count there were over 90,000 Indian students enrolled in courses Down Under, making India the second top source for Australia's international education industry next only to China. Indian students now earn for Australia close to Rs 7,600 crore in foreign exchange.

Last month though, Australia's reputation in India as a fun-loving, beer-swilling, cricket-crazy nation took a severe knocking after a spate of suspected racist attacks and hate crimes were reported against Indian students. While reports had been coming in of a growing number of such attacks in the past few months, what caught the headlines was when 25-year-old Shravan Kumar Theerthala, a student from Andhra Pradesh, was stabbed with a screwdriver and three other Indian students were beaten at a party allegedly by a group of locals in Melbourne, the capital of Victoria. Melbourne houses

almost half of the Indian students in Australia and the incident sent shockwaves across the community. Soon after there were reports that Baljinder Singh, a hospitality graduate, was stabbed in the stomach by two attackers, who first robbed him of his cash and then knifed him.

Then as the chorus of concern grew, cricketer Harbhajan Singh's cousin Jagjit Singh alleged that his 26-year-old son Upkar Singh Badal was killed as part of an alleged hate crime and his body thrown on a railway track in Melbourne. In Sydney, an Indian stu-

dent alleged that a petrol bomb was hurled at him by local miscreants resulting in him suffering burns on his body. And back in Melbourne, even as Australian authorities announced steps to clamp down on such crimes, Nardeep Singh, a 21-year-old nursing student, was confronted by five men at a campus in the city's south-east. He refused to obey their instructions to hand over his money and cigarettes after which one of the men slashed his chest with a box-cutter resulting in minor lacerations.

As worried and fearful Indian students held a massive rally, calling for Australians to act against hate crimes, the new Manmohan Singh Government was quick to express its outrage over the incidents. External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna said he was "appalled" by such attacks and wanted the Australian Government to act swiftly. Manmohan called up his Australian counterpart Kevin Rudd to express his concern.

Diplomacy apart, there was also



AN INDIAN INJURED DURING A PROTEST GETS TREATED IN MELBOURNE

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